STREAMER SCHOOL

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1-Day Intensive · Student Handout · Condensed from the 2-Day Program

8 hrs	~5 hrs	8	6
7:30 AM – 3:45 PM	ON-WATER TIME	SESSIONS	PILLARS INTRODUCED

Fly Design · Color Theory · Line Density Systems · Retrieval Vocabulary · Water Reading · Applied Hunting

> *"The real magic comes from matching colors to water type and weather conditions. You can have the most sophisticated fly in the box and still blank if the color doesn't fit the conditions. Color is the door you knock on first."*

> Instructor note: fly design and color theory are taught on the bank before touching the water — this is non-negotiable. Both sessions are compressed but must not be skipped. The passive swing and walk-the-dog sessions are deferred to the 2-day program. Focus the on-water time on strip-strip-pause, jerk-strip, direction change, and the first-cast rule.

Quick Reference

FLY CATEGORIES — SIX TYPES AND THEIR BEHAVIOR

CATEGORY	BEHAVIOR & BEST USE
JIGGER	Dumbbell or tungsten eyes. Heavy, sinks fast. Vertical bounce on pause. Near-bottom cold-water tool.
SWIMMER	Conehead or no weight. Fast, continuous retrieve. Materials shed water and dart. Clear, cold conditions.
DIVER	Deer hair or foam head. Buoyant, dives on strip, surfaces on pause. Creates direction change and turbulence.
WALKER	Wedge head (Drunk & Disorderly style). Erratic side-to-side on strip. Reaction-strike trigger.
CLASSIC SWING	Marabou/rabbit strip. Fished on the swing like a wet fly. Materials pulse with current.
ARTICULATED	Hinged two-section body. Rear moves independently of head — most lifelike action on direction change.

COLOR MATCHING — CONDITIONS TO COLOR LOGIC

CONDITIONS	COLOR LOGIC
CLEAR WATER + BRIGHT SUN	Natural tones: olive, white, tan, brown — fish inspect closely; sparse flash only
CLEAR WATER + OVERCAST	UV materials, subtle flash: pearl, light chartreuse, soft bi-color
STAINED / OFF-COLOR	High contrast: black, chartreuse, purple, fire orange — silhouette over shade
TURBID / DIRTY WATER	Loudest possible: chartreuse, yellow, hot orange — lateral line + maximum visibility
LOW LIGHT / DAWN / DUSK	Dark silhouettes: black, dark olive — hold contrast against sky
POST-STORM / RISING WATER	Bright with rattle: chartreuse + orange, or all-black — larger profile, push water
ROTATION RULE	Natural first → stained: step louder every 20 min with no contact → shift one step per condition change

LINE DENSITY — WHAT EACH DOES TO THE FLY

LINE	EFFECT
FLOATING	Maximum fly action — swimmer darts freely on pause. Best for shallow water, banks, active fish.
INTERMEDIATE (1–2 IPS)	Subtle depth, minimal surface drag — clear water, slow pools, stealthy presentations.
SINK TIP 10–15 FT (TYPE 3)	Runs and pools to 6 ft — maintains floating running line for cast ease.
SINK TIP (TYPE 5–6)	Deep runs, high water, cold tailwaters — sustained depth in fast current.
FULL SINKING LINE	Entire retrieve stays at depth — lake fishing, deep tailwater pools, maximum depth.
INTEGRATED SHOOTING HEAD	Dense short head + floating running line — best turnover for large, wind-resistant flies.
LINE + FLY INTERACTION	Floating line → diver surfaces on pause; sink tip → diver held at depth. Same fly, different behavior.

RETRIEVAL VOCABULARY — EIGHT KEY RETRIEVES

RETRIEVE	EXECUTION & TRIGGER
STRIP-STRIP-PAUSE	Two pulls, pause — fly flutters like injured prey. Foundation of all streamer retrieves.
JERK-STRIP (GALLOUP)	Rod jerk + line strip in rapid succession — erratic direction change on every beat. High-speed trigger.
SLOW GLIDE	Long slow strips, extended pause — cold, inactive, or pressured fish in deep pools.
WALK-THE-DOG	Lateral head movement on each strip — requires wedge-head fly. Side-to-side direction change.
JIGGING RETRIEVE	Rod-tip vertical oscillation — dumbbell-eye fly bounces near bottom. Near-bottom cold-water method.
DEAD DRIFT TO ANIMATE	Let fly drift naturally, then 1–2 sharp strips — surprise attack on stationary predator.
FOLLOWER PROTOCOL	Speed up → change direction → sudden stop. Force the decision within 3 casts.
SHORT STRIKE RESPONSE	Pause immediately after missed hit, then rip — fish that missed will return.

THE DECISION SEQUENCE — HOW TO CHOOSE ON THE WATER

#	STEP	DETAIL
1	**READ CONDITIONS**	What is the water clarity? What is the light? What is the weather doing?
2	**SELECT COLOR**	Apply physics: clear+sun=natural; stained=contrast; dirty=loud; low light=dark silhouette.
3	**CHOOSE LINE**	Match density to depth needed and fly action required — not just depth.
4	**PICK FLY CATEGORY**	Jigger for cold/deep; swimmer for fast/clear; diver for active/mid-depth; walker for reaction strikes.
5	**SELECT RETRIEVE**	Start with strip-strip-pause. Adjust cadence, speed, and direction based on fish response.
6	**COVER WATER**	Cast angle → retrieve → step → repeat. First cast to every lie is the highest-probability presentation.

1-Day Intensive — Streamer School

7:30 – 8:15 am — Fly design overview — categories, materials & head behavior — FLY DESIGN

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the three fly categories: jigger, swimmer, and diver/walker
- Know what each material does: marabou breathes, rabbit undulates, schlappen pushes water
- Understand head design: conehead sinks, deer hair dives, dumbbell jigs, wedge walks
- Establish color as the primary condition-matching variable for the day

KEY CONCEPTS

Three categories: jigger (vertical), swimmer (continuous fast retrieve), diver/walker (direction change) · Marabou: breathing motion; rabbit strip: undulation at rest; schlappen: water push in current · Conehead: sinks fast, jigging on pause; deer hair: buoyant, dives and surfaces; dumbbell: inverted hook jigging · Sparse = fast swimmer for clear water; dense = push-water pattern for stained or low-light conditions

ACTIVITIES

- Fly board: 8 patterns — students call the swimming category and primary material function for each
- Quick tank or bathtub demo: observe conehead vs. deer hair on the pause — sink vs. surface

> **Checkpoint:** Each student correctly categorizes 8 patterns and identifies 3 material functions before going to the water.

8:15 – 9:15 am — Color theory — the real magic of streamer fishing — COLOR

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply the contrast-over-color rule to stained and turbid water
- Match fly color to clarity, light, and weather condition using physics logic
- Build a rotation protocol — when to step louder, when to step back

KEY CONCEPTS

Clear + sun: natural (olive, white, tan); clear + overcast: UV/pearl/light chartreuse · Stained: high contrast (black, chartreuse, purple, fire orange); dirty: loudest possible · Low light / dawn / dusk: dark silhouettes — black or dark olive · Rotation: natural first → no contact after 20 min → step one shade louder → repeat

ACTIVITIES

- Color decision table: 6 condition scenarios — students assign color and physics justification
- River condition read: instructor calls today's conditions — students select color from their box first

> **MAC**
> *"Color matching to conditions is the real magic of streamer fishing. The retrieve matters — but color is the door you knock on first."*

> **Checkpoint:** Each student correctly assigns color logic to 5 of 6 scenarios before going to the water.

9:15 – 10:00 am — Line systems — choosing density for today's conditions — LINES

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Match line density to water depth, current speed, and fly category
- Understand how line density changes fly behavior — not just depth
- Select a line for today's water with justification

KEY CONCEPTS

Floating: maximum fly action — shallow water, banks, active fish; diver surfaces on pause · Intermediate (1–2 IPS): subtle depth, minimal drag — clear and slow presentations · Sink tip Type 3–5: most common river choice — depth + casting ease of floating running line · Full sinking: sustained deep retrieve — rarely needed on Appalachian rivers

ACTIVITIES

- Line comparison: same fly on floating and sink tip — student describes the behavioral difference
- Water assignment: select line and leader length for today's water type and justify the choice

MAC

"Line choice isn't just about depth — it's about how the fly behaves. A diver on floating does something completely different than on a sink tip."

Checkpoint: Each student selects line and leader length for today's conditions and can explain the behavioral impact on the fly.

10:00 – 10:45 am *Walk to water — students carry 3 colors and 2 line choices*

10:45 am – 12:15 pm Retrieval mechanics — strip-strip-pause, jerk-strip & direction change RETRIEVAL

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute strip-strip-pause, jerk-strip, slow glide, and dead drift-to-animate with distinct cadence
- Understand why change of direction triggers more strikes than speed alone
- Convert a follower using systematic retrieval adjustment

KEY CONCEPTS

Strip-strip-pause: foundation — two pulls, flutter on pause — injured prey · Jerk-strip: rod jerk + line strip — erratic high-speed direction change on every beat · Slow glide: long slow strips, extended pause — cold or inactive fish · Dead drift to animate: sink, then 1-2 sharp strips — surprise attack · Change of direction: most consistent trigger — fly changes direction = escaping prey · Follower protocol: speed up → direction change → sudden stop — force the decision

ACTIVITIES

- Retrieval drill: 4 retrieves, 5 casts each — execute distinctly and name each one
- Follower conversion: instructor calls 'follower' — student adjusts within 2 casts
- Fly watch in flat water: observe own fly's behavior on each retrieve type before targeting fish

MAC

"The retrieve is where the game is really won or lost. Change of direction and speed variation are the two most consistent strike triggers I know."

Checkpoint: Each student demonstrates 4 distinct retrieves and executes a follower-conversion on command.

12:15 – 1:00 pm *Lunch — students walk the afternoon run and identify 5 prime streamer lies*

1:00 – 2:00 pm Reading water for streamers & the approach cast WATER READING

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Target undercut banks, wood, depth transitions, and seam edges as ambush architecture
- Apply the first-cast rule: make the first presentation count
- Execute the approach cast angle and mend before the retrieve begins

KEY CONCEPTS

Ambush architecture: structure + depth transition + adjacent current · Undercut banks: closest to the bank wins — 5 hard strips then move on · Wood: within 6 inches or don't bother · First cast rule: first presentation to any new lie = highest-probability cast · Cast angle determines retrieval arc — across-and-down vs. up-and-across

ACTIVITIES

- Lie identification: student walks a 30-yard run and assigns a retrieve approach to each feature
- Cast angle drill: 3 different angles to same target — observe how arc changes
- Bank-targeting: land fly within 18 inches of bank — 10 repetitions

Checkpoint: Each student correctly identifies 4 lie types and grids a 30-yard run without skipping structure.

2:00 – 3:00 pm Independent hunting session APPLIED

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Self-select fly, color, line, and retrieve without instructor input
- Cover assigned water systematically without camping on unproductive lies
- Make and verbalize at least 2 condition-based adjustments during the session

ACTIVITIES

- Independent 40-minute water hunt: fully self-directed decisions
- Self-report: flies used, retrieves employed, adjustments made, fish contact

> **MAC**
> *“The real magic is when all the pieces connect — right color, right line, right retrieve. That’s learned from hunting with intention.”*

Checkpoint: Student covers the run and can debrief every gear decision with logic.

3:00 – 3:45 pm Final debrief, written feedback & 30-day plan REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one retrieval and one color priority
- Build a 30-day streamer practice plan

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment: fly classification, color logic, line selection, retrieval vocabulary, water reading
- Individual feedback: one strength, one priority, one habit for every outing
- 30-day plan: one retrieval focus per outing, color journal per session

Checkpoint: Completed assessment returned to each student.